MODULE 44 · FOUNDATIONS - ALL DOMAINS

How PMP questions are written

The exam's format, its eight question types, the anatomy of a question, qualifiers and distractors, pacing, the breaks and scoring.

DOMAIN Cross-domain EXAM WEIGHT All domains MODULE 44 of 49

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Every question is a small project situation with **one decision** at its centre.

The exam at a glance

FEATURE	FROM 9 JULY 2026
Questions	180: 170 scored, and 10 unscored pretest items you cannot tell apart
Time	240 minutes: about 80 seconds per question
Structure	A case-study section first, then independent questions
Breaks	Two optional 10-minute breaks
Domains	People 33%, Process 41%, Business Environment 26%
Approaches	About 40% predictive; 60% adaptive, agile and hybrid

ON THE EXAM

Sixty percent of questions sit in adaptive or hybrid settings. Read which approach each scenario uses.

The breaks

- The first break is offered after the **case-study section**.
- The second is offered about **midway** through the independent questions.
- Once you review your answers and take a break, you **cannot return** to the previous section.
- Review flagged questions in a section **before** starting its break.
- Take the breaks. Ten minutes of rest usually repays itself in accuracy.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Finish reviewing each section before its break. There is no going back afterwards.

Eight question types

TYPE	WHAT YOU DO
Multiple choice	Choose one answer from four
Multiple response	Choose a stated number of answers, such as 'choose two'
Matching and enhanced matching	Pair items, such as terms with definitions
Point-and-click	Click the right place on an image or chart
Pull-down list	Choose the right option within a sentence or table
Case or scenario (new)	Answer several questions about one extended case
Graphic-based (new)	Interpret a chart, diagram or table to answer

ON THE EXAM

Two types are new in 2026: case or scenario, and graphic-based. The rest are established formats.

Case-study sets

- First pass: note the **approach**, the **phase**, and the **people**. They change what 'right' means.
- Read each question's call, then go back to the case for the **one detail** that decides it.
- Carry forward what you have learned. Each question adds to the picture.
- Re-reading the whole case for every question burns time you will need later.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Map the case once: approach, phase, people. Then hunt for details question by question.

The anatomy of a question

01
Context
The project, the approach, the people.

02
Complication
What has happened or changed.

03
The detail
Often the second sentence: the fact that decides it.

04
The call
What exactly is asked: first, next, best, should have.

05
Options
One best answer, and three plausible distractors.

ON THE EXAM

Find the deciding detail and the call before reading the options.

Qualifiers change the question

THE CALL SAYS	WHAT IT MEANS
What should the PM do first?	The earliest right step, usually understanding or assessing
What should the PM do next?	Something has already happened; take the following step
What is the best action?	Several are reasonable; choose the most complete and appropriate
What should the PM have done?	Prevention: what would have stopped this happening
What is the most likely cause?	Diagnosis, not action

ON THE EXAM

'First' and 'next' often have different answers for the same scenario. Read the qualifier twice.

The distractors you will meet

DISTRACTOR PATTERN	WHY IT IS WRONG
Acts beyond authority	Decides what belongs to the sponsor, product owner or board
Escalates too early	Skips assessing and collaborating (module 02's ladder)
Ignores or waits	Leaves a real problem to grow
Blames or punishes	Treats a system problem as a person's fault
Only documents	Records the problem but does nothing about it
Right action, wrong time	Good in principle, but not the first or next step

ON THE EXAM

Most wrong answers fit one of these six patterns. Name the pattern, and the option falls away.

A method for every question

- **1.** Note the approach and your role.
- **2.** Find the real problem and the deciding detail.
- **3.** Read the call and its qualifier.
- **4.** Eliminate options that fit a distractor pattern.
- **5.** Between the last two, choose the one earlier on the ladder: understand, assess, collaborate, act, escalate.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Approach, problem, call, eliminate, ladder. Practise it until it takes seconds.

Pacing

- About **80 seconds** per question on average.
- Case-study questions and graphics take longer; short situational questions take less.
- Check the clock every 40 to 50 questions, not after each one.
- Stuck after a minute and a half? Choose your best answer, **flag** it, and move on.
- Answer every question. An unanswered question is simply marked wrong.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Never leave a question blank. Flag and move on; come back before the section's break.

Scoring

- PMI does not publish a numeric passing score or a pass rate.
- The ten pretest items do not count, and cannot be identified.
- Results show your performance in each domain, against a target level.
- Up to three attempts are allowed within your eligibility period.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> There is no target percentage to chase. Aim to be solid in all three domains.

Exam-day essentials

- Online or at a test centre: check the current rules in PMI's exam handbook.
- Valid identification that exactly matches your registration name.
- Use the on-screen calculator and the whiteboard for calculations and quick notes.
- Sleep, eat, and arrive early. Four hours of concentration is a physical task.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Logistics change. Check PMI's current handbook in the week before your exam.

> A team member tells the project manager that a key vendor may miss its delivery date by about two weeks. The delivery is on the critical path.
>
> The project manager has not yet spoken to the vendor.

What should the project manager do FIRST?

A Update the schedule to show a two-week delay.

B Verify the situation with the vendor and assess the impact on the project.

C Inform the sponsor that the project will be two weeks late.

D Invoke the contract's late-delivery penalty clause.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do FIRST?

A Update the schedule.
Right action, wrong time: the delay is not yet confirmed.

B Verify and assess.
First means understand: confirm the facts and their impact.

C Tell the sponsor it will be late.
Reports unverified information as fact.

D Invoke the penalty clause.
Acts on a rumour, and damages the relationship.

THE QUALIFIER

'First', with unverified information: understand and assess before acting.

> The project manager has now confirmed with the vendor that delivery will be two weeks late, delaying the critical path. The risk register identified this risk, with a planned response: switch to a pre-qualified second vendor.
>
> The response is within the project manager's authority.

What should the project manager do NEXT?

A Escalate the delay to the sponsor for a decision.

B Crash the remaining critical path activities.

C Implement the planned response and switch to the second vendor.

D Wait to see whether the vendor recovers some of the time.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do NEXT?

A Escalate.

Escalates too early: a planned response exists within authority.

B Crash the schedule.

An unplanned, costly response when a planned one exists.

C Implement the planned response.

The facts are confirmed; the prepared response is the next step.

D Wait.

Ignores a confirmed delay on the critical path.

THE QUALIFIER

Same scenario, new qualifier, new answer. 'Next', with facts confirmed and a plan ready: act on the plan.

> At go-live, warehouse staff reject a new stock system because it does not match how they actually pick orders. The requirements were written by managers, and staff were not consulted.
>
> The system meets its documented requirements.

What should the project manager have done?

A. Involved warehouse staff early, eliciting requirements from them and validating the workflow with prototypes.

B. Written a more detailed contract with the software supplier.

C. Carried out more system testing before go-live.

D. Provided more training to warehouse staff before go-live.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager have done?

A Involve users early; prototype.

Prevents the root cause: requirements that missed how work is really done.

B Tighter contract.

The supplier built what was specified. The specification was the problem.

C More testing.

Tests against the same wrong requirements, and passes.

D More training.

Teaches people to use a system that does not fit their work.

THE QUALIFIER

'Should have' asks for prevention at the root cause. Here, the missing stakeholders.

> An agile team's velocity has fallen for three sprints. In the retrospective, developers say several stakeholders contact them directly throughout each sprint with urgent requests.
>
> The team has a product owner.

What is the BEST action for the project leader?

A Ask the team to work longer hours to restore velocity.

B Report the falling velocity to the sponsor.

C Lengthen the sprints so there is more room for interruptions.

D Work with the stakeholders and product owner so requests go through the backlog, protecting the team's focus.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the BEST action for the project leader?

A Longer hours.
Treats the symptom, at the cost of sustainable pace.

B Report to the sponsor.
Only documents; the leader can remove this impediment.

C Longer sprints.
Accommodates the interruptions instead of removing them.

D Route requests through the product owner and backlog.
Removes the impediment at its cause, as a servant leader should.

THE QUALIFIER

'Best' among plausible options: the one that fixes the cause, by the right person, in the right way.

Find the decision. **Read the qualifier.** Name the distractor. Climb the ladder.

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